Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 20 · DAYS 725-752

The New Covenant Explained: Romans

Romans 1-16

The righteousness of God revealed. Justification, sanctification, and God's purposes in history.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 8:1

Psalms 32, 143, 19, and 117, which Paul quotes in Romans, with 130 and 116.

UNIT 20

In this unit

WEEK 104

725	Romans 1:1-32	*Reading*
726	Romans 1:18-32; Nahum 1:2-8	*Doctrine*
727	Romans 2:1-29	*Reading*
728	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 105

729	Romans 3:1-31	*Reading*
730	Romans 3:21-31; Romans 4:1-8; Galatians 2:15-21	*Doctrine*
731	Romans 4:1-25	*Reading*
732	Psalm 32	*Psalm*
733	Psalm 130	*Psalm*
734	Psalm 143:1-12	*Psalm*
735	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 106

736	Romans 5:1-21	*Reading*
737	Romans 6:1-14; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:4-10	*Doctrine*
738	Romans 6:1-23	*Reading*
739	Romans 7:1-25	*Reading*
740	Romans 6:1-14; 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8; Philippians 2:12-13	*Doctrine*
741	Romans 8:1-39	*Reading*
742	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 107

743	Romans 9:1-33	*Reading*
744	Romans 10:1-11:36	*Reading*
745	Psalm 19:1-6	*Psalm*
746	Psalm 116	*Psalm*

747	Psalm 117	*Psalm*
748	Romans 12:1-13:14	*Reading*
749	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 108

750	Romans 14:1-15:13	*Reading*
751	Romans 15:14-16:27	*Reading*
752	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 725 · WEEK 104

Romans 1:1-32

The gospel; the righteousness of God; the wrath of God

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 1:1-32. This is the opening of Paul's greatest letter. Read the greeting (1:1-7), then the theme statement (1:16-17), and then the dark diagnosis of the human race (1:18-32). Ask what makes the gospel good news, and why it must begin with bad news.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul writes to the church in Rome from Corinth, around AD 57, at the end of his third missionary journey. He has never been to Rome, but he hopes to visit on his way to Spain. The church is made up of Jewish and Gentile believers who have tensions between them. Paul writes the fullest explanation of the gospel found anywhere in Scripture: how sinners are made right with a holy God, how they are changed, and how God's promises to Israel and the nations fit together. Romans is the great explanation of the new covenant. The Reformation was lit by it, and countless believers have been converted while reading it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Paul, a servant of Christ Jesus, called to be an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God" (1:1).
2. "And was declared to be the Son of God in power according to the Spirit of holiness by his resurrection from the dead, Jesus Christ our Lord" (1:4).
3. "For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek" (1:16).
4. "For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, The righteous shall live by faith" (1:17).

5. “For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth” (1:18).
6. “For his invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made” (1:20).
7. “For although they knew God, they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him” (1:21).
8. “Because they exchanged the truth about God for a lie and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator, who is blessed forever! Amen” (1:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul introduces himself as a servant, literally a slave, of Christ Jesus, an apostle, set apart for the gospel of God. He immediately says that this gospel was promised beforehand through the prophets in the holy Scriptures. The good news is not new. It is the fulfillment of the Old Testament. Its subject is God’s Son, descended from David according to the flesh and declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection from the dead. Through him, Paul has received grace and apostleship “to bring about the obedience of faith for the sake of his name among all the nations.” He writes to Romans who are “called to be saints.” Every Christian is a saint, a holy one set apart by God.

Paul longs to see them, to impart some spiritual gift, and to be mutually encouraged. Then he gives the thesis of the whole letter: “I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.” The gospel is not advice; it is power. It saves. And it saves “everyone who believes,” on one condition. Verse 17 states the heart: “In it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, The righteous shall live by faith.” This is a quotation of Habakkuk 2:4. The righteousness of God here is God’s saving action and the gift of righteous standing that he gives. Martin Luther said that when he understood this phrase he felt he had entered paradise through open gates.

But why do we need the gospel? Paul now tells the bad news. “The wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth.” People know God from creation: his eternal power and divine nature are clearly perceived in the things he has made. So no one has an excuse. The problem is not lack of information but suppression of it. They knew God, but they did not honor him as God or give thanks. Their thinking became futile, their hearts darkened. Claiming to be wise, they became fools, exchanging the glory of the immortal God for images. Three times, Paul says, “God gave them up”: to impurity, to dishonorable passions, to

a debased mind. God's judgment here takes the form of letting sin run its course. The chapter ends with a long list of sins and the sober note that they not only do these things but give approval to those who practice them.

This is hard reading. But it prepares the way. A doctor who diagnoses cancer gently cannot be trusted. Paul tells the truth so that the good news may be heard as good.

STEP 5

Connection

Habakkuk 2:4 is the source of 1:17. Psalm 19:1-4 declares that the heavens proclaim God's glory. Genesis 1 to 3 is the background for the fall in 1:21-25. Acts 14:15-17 and 17:22-31 show Paul preaching the same truth about creation. Jeremiah 2:11-13 describes exchanging glory for what cannot profit. Ephesians 4:17-19 describes darkened understanding. 1 Corinthians 1:18-25 speaks of the power of the cross. Romans 3:21 to 5:21 will answer the problem posed here.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 1:16 and ask whether you are ashamed of the gospel in any setting. Where are you tempted to stay silent?

Ask what you honor above God or give thanks for in a way that forgets the Giver.

Thank God that he does not leave us at the end of Romans 1.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gospel, the power for salvation.
- Ask him to keep you from shame in it.
- Thank him that the righteous shall live by faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 726 · WEEK 104

Romans 1:18-32; Nahum 1:2-8

Divine opposition to sin

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 1:18-32 again, and then Nahum 1:2-8. Today is a doctrinal pause on the wrath of God. The question is simple and hard: how can a God of love be angry? Read slowly, and notice that Nahum holds wrath and goodness together in the same breath.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Many people are uneasy with the idea that God is angry. Some picture the God of the Old Testament as wrathful and the God of the New as gentle, but the New Testament speaks of wrath at least as often as the Old. Paul says it is the first thing "revealed" in the gospel's unfolding (Romans 1:18). The prophet Nahum, writing perhaps a century after Jonah, announces judgment on Nineveh, the same city that repented under Jonah and later returned to cruelty. Together the two passages give us a biblical view of divine opposition to sin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men" (Romans 1:18).
2. "Therefore God gave them up in the lusts of their hearts to impurity" (Romans 1:24).
3. "For this reason God gave them up to dishonorable passions" (Romans 1:26).
4. "God gave them up to a debased mind to do what ought not to be done" (Romans 1:28).
5. "The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful" (Nahum 1:2).

6. “The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty” (Nahum 1:3).

7. “Who can stand before his indignation? Who can endure the heat of his anger?” (Nahum 1:6).

8. “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him” (Nahum 1:7).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The wrath of God is his settled, holy, and righteous opposition to all evil. It is not a loss of temper. Human anger is often selfish, sudden, and out of control. God’s wrath is none of these. It flows from his holiness and his love of what is good. A God who did not hate injustice, cruelty, and the destruction of his creatures would not be good. If we love victims, we should want a God who is angry at what harms them.

Scripture describes wrath in at least two ways. In Romans 1, wrath is revealed in the present, as God gives people over to the consequences of their own choices: sin becomes its own punishment. And elsewhere wrath is future: Paul speaks of a “day of wrath when God’s righteous judgment will be revealed” (Romans 2:5). Nahum shows God’s wrath as both patient and certain: “slow to anger,” yet he “will by no means clear the guilty.”

The wrath of God is the background that makes the gospel good news. At the cross, Jesus bore this wrath for his people. The word “propitiation” (Romans 3:25) means a sacrifice that turns away wrath. Christians have debated the word, but its main meaning is clear: God’s justice and God’s love meet at the cross, where the Son absorbs what sin deserves. Therefore, for the believer, “there is now no condemnation” (Romans 8:1). Nahum 1:7 is the comfort: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” The same God who is a fire to his enemies is a refuge to those who run to him. Christians differ on how to describe the final punishment of the unrepentant, but all agree that God’s judgment is just.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says wrath “is revealed from heaven.” It is not a mere theory; it is evident in the moral order of the world. Then he describes its form three times: “God gave them up.” Notice the pattern. People suppress the truth, and God gives them up to impurity (verse 24). They exchange the truth about God for a lie, and God gives them up to dishonorable passions (verse 26). They do not see fit to acknowledge God, and God gives them up to a debased mind

(verse 28). The result is a downward spiral. Sin is not merely breaking rules; it is worship turned the wrong way. When we will not worship the Creator, we worship the creature, and the creature cannot bear the weight.

Nahum brings the other side of the picture. The prophet opens with a hymn to the character of God. “The LORD is a jealous and avenging God.” Jealous here means that he will not share his glory or his people with idols, as a husband is rightly jealous for his wife. “Slow to anger and great in power,” a phrase that echoes Exodus 34:6-7. Slow to anger means patience, not weakness. Nineveh had been given time and a prophet. But patience has an end. Mountains quake before him, and the earth heaves. “Who can stand before his indignation?”

Then, in the middle of the storm, the verse that changes the tone: “The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.” There are only two kinds of people before this God: those who stand against him and those who take refuge in him. The gospel is the invitation to refuge. Jesus is the place where the storm has already broken. Wrath fell on him at Calvary so that it would not fall on us.

When we say we are unsettled by the wrath of God, we do well to ask what it would mean for him not to be angry at evil. Paul teaches that the cure for our unease is not to quiet the doctrine but to run to the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 34:6-7 describes the character of God with mercy and justice. Psalm 7:11 says God is angry with the wicked every day. John 3:36 speaks of the wrath of God remaining on those who do not believe. Romans 2:5, 5:9, and 1 Thessalonians 1:10 speak of wrath to come and our deliverance. Romans 3:25 and 1 John 4:10 speak of propitiation. Hebrews 12:28-29 says our God is a consuming fire. Jonah 3 to 4 is the earlier chapter of Nineveh’s story. Revelation 6:15-17 describes the wrath of the Lamb.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you have been tempted to soften what Scripture says about God’s wrath, and why.

If you are afraid of God’s judgment, take refuge in Christ today. Say the words of Nahum 1:7 as a prayer.

Pray for someone you love who does not yet see their need of a Savior.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have wanted a God without wrath.
- Ask him to teach you to see his wrath and his mercy together.
- Thank Jesus for bearing wrath for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 727 · WEEK 104

Romans 2:1-29

God's righteous judgment; circumcision of the heart

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 2:1-29. Paul turns from the obvious sinners to the religious and moral person. Notice the standard of God's judgment, and what Paul means by a Jew "inwardly."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the dark picture in chapter 1, a Jewish reader might say, "Yes, those pagans deserve it!" Paul now closes the trap. In the style of a diatribe, a lively argument with an imaginary opponent, he shows that the moral person and the religious person are also under judgment. Having the Law, being circumcised, and belonging to the covenant people are not a shelter from God's verdict. Paul's point is that every mouth must be stopped (3:19).

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Therefore you have no excuse, O man, every one of you who judges. For in passing judgment on another you condemn yourself, because you, the judge, practice the very same things" (2:1).
2. "Or do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God's kindness is meant to lead you to repentance?" (2:4).
3. "He will render to each one according to his works" (2:6).
4. "For God shows no partiality" (2:11).
5. "For it is not the hearers of the law who are righteous before God, but the doers of the law who will be justified" (2:13).

6. “They show that the work of the law is written on their hearts, while their conscience also bears witness” (2:15).

7. “On that day when, according to my gospel, God judges the secrets of men by Christ Jesus” (2:16).

8. “But a Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter” (2:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the person who judges others: “You have no excuse.” Those who condemn others for the same sins they commit prove that they know right from wrong and fail to keep it. God’s judgment is according to truth. Then comes a lovely question: “Do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God’s kindness is meant to lead you to repentance?” God’s patience is not approval. It is a window of mercy. To ignore it is to store up wrath for the day of wrath.

God will “render to each one according to his works.” This sentence raises a question that students of Romans have asked for centuries: does Paul teach salvation by works? No. He is describing the standard of the final judgment. God will judge impartially, by works, because works reveal the heart. Eternal life goes to those who by patience in doing good seek glory and honor and immortality; wrath to those who are self-seeking and do not obey the truth. But Paul will go on to show that no one meets this standard (3:9-20), and the believer’s works are the fruit and evidence of faith, not its foundation. The judgment according to works does not contradict justification by faith. It shows that real faith produces a changed life.

Paul next addresses the Jew who relies on the Law and boasts in God. He asks four hard questions: you teach others, do you teach yourself? You say not to steal, do you steal? Do you commit adultery? Do you rob temples? “The name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you,” he writes, quoting Isaiah 52:5. Circumcision has value if you keep the law, but if you break it, your circumcision becomes uncircumcision. And an uncircumcised man who keeps the law’s requirements will be counted as circumcised.

The chapter closes with the center of the new covenant: “A Jew is one inwardly, and circumcision is a matter of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the letter.” This echoes Deuteronomy 30:6 and Jeremiah 31:33. The true people of God are those whose hearts the Spirit has changed. Outward signs without inward reality count for nothing. This is a key text for progressive covenantalism: the promises made to Israel find their fulfillment in a people marked by the Spirit, Jew and Gentile together in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 10:16 and 30:6 call for circumcision of the heart. Jeremiah 9:25-26 and 31:31-34 speak of the heart and the new covenant. Ezekiel 36:26-27 promises the Spirit. Matthew 7:1-5 is Jesus on judging. Matthew 23 condemns hypocrisy. Ecclesiastes 12:14 says God will bring every deed into judgment. 2 Corinthians 5:10 says we must appear before the judgment seat of Christ. Philippians 3:3 says we are the circumcision, who worship by the Spirit of God. Galatians 6:15 says neither circumcision nor uncircumcision counts for anything, but a new creation.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you judge others for what you do yourself. Confess it.

Think of a time when God's kindness led you to repentance. Thank him for it.

Examine whether your faith is outward or has reached the heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you judge others and excuse yourself.
- Ask him to circumcise your heart.
- Thank him for his kindness that leads you to repentance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 728 · WEEK 104

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 1:16 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

REST

Meditation

Paul writes this verse at the start of the greatest explanation of the gospel ever written.

"I am not ashamed of the gospel." Paul says this because the gospel is easy to be ashamed of. It speaks of a crucified Savior, which seemed foolish to Greeks and offensive to Jews. It tells us we are sinners who cannot save ourselves. The world's wisdom has not changed. And yet Paul is not ashamed. His boldness does not come from temperament but from conviction.

"For it is the power of God for salvation." The gospel is not only information or a good idea. It is the power of God, the means by which he saves. When it is preached, God works. Dead hearts are raised, and enemies become children.

"To everyone who believes." The gospel has a condition that is not a work: believing. It rests on Christ and not on us. It is open to all.

“To the Jew first and also to the Greek.” The gospel came to Israel first, and the promises were theirs. But it goes beyond to every nation. In Romans, Paul will show how Jew and Gentile are saved the same way.

When you are tempted to be quiet about your faith, say this verse. The power does not rest in your ability to explain, but in the gospel itself.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Paul’s letter to the Romans, the great explanation of the new covenant. You read the opening greeting and the statement of the theme: the gospel is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, and in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith. Then Paul gave the bad news that makes the good news necessary. God’s wrath is revealed against all who suppress the truth, and he gives them up to the consequences of their sin. In a doctrinal pause, you thought about the wrath of God as his holy opposition to evil, and with Nahum you saw that the same God is a stronghold to those who take refuge in him. In chapter 2, Paul turned to the moral and religious person: God judges impartially, his kindness is meant to lead to repentance, and a true Jew is one inwardly, circumcised in heart by the Spirit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says he is not ashamed of the gospel. In what setting, with which people, are you most tempted to be ashamed or silent about Christ? What would it look like to speak with quiet confidence there?

Romans 1 and 2 show that everyone, religious or not, is guilty before God. How does the cross of Jesus, where he bore the wrath we deserved, change the way you feel when you read these chapters?

Paul says God’s kindness is meant to lead you to repentance. Where is God’s kindness leading you to turn right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel, the power for salvation.

Ask him to keep you from shame and make you bold.

Rest in his righteousness.

DAY 729 · WEEK 105

Romans 3:1-31

All have sinned; justification by faith

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 3:1-31. This chapter is the hinge of the letter. Read the verdict in 3:9-20 and then the great turn at 3:21, “But now.” Take your time with 3:21-26, one of the most important passages in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has argued that Gentiles (chapter 1) and Jews (chapter 2) are all under God’s judgment. Chapter 3 begins with objections: if the Jews are guilty too, what advantage has the Jew? Does unbelief cancel God’s faithfulness? Paul answers briefly, then delivers the verdict on the whole human race. Then, like sunrise, the next section begins with “But now.” The righteousness of God has been manifested.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To begin with, the Jews were entrusted with the oracles of God” (3:2).
2. “None is righteous, no, not one” (3:10).
3. “For by works of the law no human being will be justified in his sight, since through the law comes knowledge of sin” (3:20).
4. “But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it” (3:21).
5. “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (3:23).
6. “And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus” (3:24).
7. “Whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith” (3:25).

8 “For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (3:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Jews have a real advantage: they were entrusted with the oracles of God, the Scriptures. But possessing the Bible is not the same as obeying it. Does Israel’s unfaithfulness nullify God’s faithfulness? “By no means! Let God be true though every one were a liar.” God’s character is not at stake in human failure. Paul answers a twisted objection, “Why not do evil that good may come?” with a short, firm rejection.

Then he gathers a series of Old Testament quotations, mostly from the Psalms and Isaiah, into a portrait of universal sin: “None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God. All have turned aside… no one does good, not even one.” Throats are open graves, feet are swift to shed blood, and “there is no fear of God before their eyes.” The point is stated at verse 19: “so that every mouth may be stopped, and the whole world may be held accountable to God.” The law cannot save because it was never given for that purpose. “Through the law comes knowledge of sin.” It is a mirror, not a rescue.

Then, “But now.” These two words mark the biggest turn in Romans. “The righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it.” This is the new covenant fulfillment of the old. The righteousness comes “through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction: for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.”

Three words carry the weight. Justified: declared righteous in God’s courtroom. Grace: a free gift, not earned. Redemption: a slave market word for being bought back with a price. And then “whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith.” Propitiation means a sacrifice that satisfies God’s wrath. God himself provides it. Paul explains why: “This was to show God’s righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins.” In the Old Testament, God forgave sin and seemed to overlook it. Now it is clear how he could do so justly: the cross. “So that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.” God is both just and the one who justifies the ungodly. That is the miracle.

Boasting is excluded. If salvation were by works, we could boast. It is by faith, so all glory goes to God. And this faith does not cancel the law; it upholds it, since Christ fulfilled it.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 14:1-3 and 53:1-3 describe human sin. Psalm 5:9, 10:7, 36:1, 140:3, and Isaiah 59:7-8 are quoted in verses 13-18. Leviticus 16 describes the Day of Atonement and the mercy seat, the background of "propitiation." Isaiah 53:4-6, 10-12 gives the Servant bearing sin. Proverbs 17:15 says that justifying the wicked is an abomination to the LORD, which makes the cross necessary. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says he became sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. Galatians 2:16 and Ephesians 2:8-9 repeat the point.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 3:23-24. They hold the whole gospel in two verses.

Ask whether you are secretly trying to earn God's favor. Let boasting be excluded today.

Thank God for the cross, where he is both just and the justifier.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have fallen short of his glory.
- Thank God for justifying you by grace as a gift.
- Thank Jesus for the redemption that is in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 730 · WEEK 105

Romans 3:21-31; Romans 4:1-8; Galatians 2:15-21

Justification by Faith Alone

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 3:21-31, Romans 4:1-8, and Galatians 2:15-21. Today is a doctrinal pause on justification by faith alone. Notice the legal language, the word “counted,” and what Paul says about works and grace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Justification by faith alone was the central issue of the Protestant Reformation. Martin Luther called it “the article by which the church stands or falls.” It is also the point at which Paul argued against those who wanted Gentile believers to take on the Jewish law. In Galatians, Paul confronts Peter in Antioch because withdrawing from Gentile believers implied that faith in Christ was not enough. The three passages together show that being right with God has always been by grace through faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law” (Romans 3:21).
2. “And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus” (Romans 3:24).
3. “So that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus” (Romans 3:26).
4. “For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (Romans 3:28).

5. “For what does the Scripture say? Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness” (Romans 4:3).
6. “And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness” (Romans 4:5).
7. “A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ” (Galatians 2:16).
8. “If righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose” (Galatians 2:21).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

To justify is to declare righteous. It is a courtroom word, not a hospital word. It describes a change of status, not of nature. In justification, God declares the sinner to be in the right, forgiven and accepted, on the basis of Christ’s work and not our own. The Reformers described this as imputation: our sin is counted as Christ’s, and his righteousness is counted as ours. Paul uses the word “counted” (or “reckoned”) eleven times in Romans 4. The great exchange happens at the cross. God does not pretend we are righteous. He treats us as righteous because Christ is righteous in our place.

Faith is the instrument, not the cause. We are justified by grace (the source), through Christ’s blood and obedience (the ground), and through faith (the means). Faith does not earn anything. It is the empty hand that receives. And “alone” means that nothing is added to faith as a condition for being right with God. But the faith that justifies is never alone; it produces works. James 2 makes this point: a claim to faith that produces no obedience is dead. Paul and James are not opposed. Paul speaks of how we are declared righteous; James speaks of how true faith is shown to be real.

Justification is once for all. The verdict of the last day is announced in advance to those who believe. “Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God” (Romans 5:1). Not “will have” but “have.” Christians have long differed here with Roman Catholic teaching, which holds that justification includes a lifelong process of being made righteous through grace-enabled works and sacraments. Evangelicals hold that sanctification follows justification and does not form part of it. Scholars today also debate the “new perspective” on Paul, which emphasizes the inclusion of Gentiles; most evangelicals receive its insight about covenant community while insisting that Paul is also teaching how sinners stand right before a holy God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that righteousness from God has been manifested "apart from the law." This does not mean the Old Testament was wrong. It means the Law and the Prophets "bear witness to it." They pointed forward to this. The righteousness comes through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe, without distinction.

Then Paul turns to Abraham, the father of the Jewish people, to prove that justification by faith is not a New Testament novelty. "What then shall we say was gained by Abraham, our forefather according to the flesh? For if Abraham was justified by works, he has something to boast about, but not before God." He quotes Genesis 15:6: "Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness." Wages are earned and owed. A gift is received. "To the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness." Notice how startling the phrase "justifies the ungodly" is. Under Old Testament law, a judge who acquits the guilty is condemned (Proverbs 17:15). Yet God does exactly this, because the penalty has been paid.

Paul then brings David as a second witness. In Psalm 32, David speaks of the blessing of the one "whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin." Forgiveness of sins and counted righteousness are two sides of the same coin.

In Galatians 2, Paul states the truth in personal terms. "We know that a person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ, so we also have believed in Christ Jesus, in order to be justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law." And he draws the conclusion: "I do not nullify the grace of God, for if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose." To add anything to faith as a requirement is to say that the cross was not enough. Those who try to be justified by the law are, in effect, setting aside Christ's death.

This doctrine is the believer's comfort and the church's boast. It does not make light of sin. It takes sin so seriously that it required the death of God's Son. And it gives certainty: our standing before God does not rise and fall with our performance, but rests on Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 15:6 is the verse behind Romans 4 and Galatians 3. Habakkuk 2:4 stands behind both letters. Psalm 32:1-2 is David's blessing of the forgiven. Isaiah 53:11 says the righteous one will make many to be accounted righteous. Jeremiah 23:6 calls the coming king "The LORD is

our righteousness.” 2 Corinthians 5:21 describes the exchange. Philippians 3:8-9 speaks of having a righteousness not my own. Ephesians 2:8-9 and Titus 3:4-7 teach salvation by grace through faith. James 2:14-26 describes faith that works.

STEP 6

Application

Write in your own words the difference between being declared righteous and being made righteous. Say it to someone this week.

When you feel guilty after failing, remind yourself that your standing before God rests on Christ’s work, not on your record.

Thank God for “counted as righteousness.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he justifies the ungodly.
- Tell him you bring nothing but faith, and even that is his gift.
- Ask him to keep you from trusting in your works.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.”

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 731 · WEEK 105

Romans 4:1-25

Abraham's faith counted as righteousness

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 4:1-25. Paul uses Abraham as a case study. Notice the timing of Abraham's faith, and the kind of faith that Paul describes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham was the Jewish people's founding father. Rabbis often taught that Abraham was justified because of his obedience, including his willingness to offer Isaac. If Paul can show that Abraham was right with God by faith, the Jewish objections collapse and the Gentiles are brought in. Genesis 15:6 is the verse on which Paul builds, and he reads it with great care.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For what does the Scripture say? Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness" (4:3).
2. "And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness" (4:5).
3. "Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered" (4:7).
4. "It was not after, but before" (4:10).
5. "He received the sign of circumcision as a seal of the righteousness that he had by faith while he was still uncircumcised" (4:11).
6. "Who gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist" (4:17).
7. "Fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised" (4:21).
8. "Who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification" (4:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul starts with a question: what did Abraham find? If he was justified by works, he would have something to boast about, but not before God. The Scripture says that Abraham believed God and it was counted to him as righteousness. Notice the verb "counted." It is bookkeeping language. Righteousness was credited to his account, not earned.

Then Paul reasons from the timeline. When was Abraham counted righteous? Before or after circumcision? Genesis 15 comes before Genesis 17. Abraham was justified long before he was circumcised, and long before the law of Moses. Circumcision was a sign and seal of a righteousness he already had by faith. The consequence is wide: Abraham is the father of all who believe without being circumcised, so that righteousness may be counted to them as well, and the father of the circumcised who also walk in the footsteps of his faith. Jew and Gentile are in the same family on the same terms.

The promise to Abraham did not come through the law, since law brings wrath, but through the righteousness of faith. "That is why it depends on faith, in order that the promise may rest on grace and be guaranteed to all his offspring." This is a central point for understanding the covenants. The Abrahamic promise, that Abraham would be the father of many nations and heir of the world, is fulfilled in Christ, and all who share his faith are his children.

Abraham's faith is described with care. God had promised him a son, but he and Sarah were old; Abraham's body was as good as dead, and Sarah's womb was barren. Yet "no unbelief made him waver concerning the promise of God, but he grew strong in his faith as he gave glory to God, fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised." He believed in a God "who gives life to the dead and calls into existence the things that do not exist." The faith that justifies is trust in the promise-keeping God, who raises the dead.

And the account was written for us. "It will be counted to us who believe in him who raised from the dead Jesus our Lord, who was delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification." The cross dealt with our sin; the resurrection is God's public declaration that the payment was accepted. Abraham looked ahead to the promise; we look back to the resurrection. The object of faith is the same God, the one who raises the dead.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12:1-3, 15:1-6, and 17:1-14 are the Abrahamic narratives. Genesis 22 is the offering of Isaac. Galatians 3:6-9 and 3:26-29 make the same argument. Hebrews 11:8-19 describes Abraham's faith. James 2:21-24 views Abraham's works as evidence of his faith. Psalm 32 is

the psalm David wrote. Isaiah 51:1-2 calls Israel to look to Abraham. Luke 1:73-75 speaks of the oath sworn to Abraham. Romans 1:4 and 8:11 connect the resurrection with justification and life.

STEP 6

Application

Compare Abraham's faith with your own. What promise of God are you called to trust, even when it seems impossible?

Give glory to God today out loud. Faith grows by giving glory.

Thank God that the resurrection of Jesus is proof the payment was accepted.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for counting faith as righteousness.
- Tell him what promise you are trusting him for.
- Ask him to strengthen your faith like Abraham's.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 732 · WEEK 105

Psalm 32

Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 32. Paul quotes the first two verses in Romans 4:7-8. Read it as David's testimony of what it feels like to be justified, and notice the difference between hiding sin and confessing it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 32 is a psalm of David, called a "Maskil," which means a teaching psalm. It is traditionally linked to David's sin with Bathsheba and the long months of silence before Nathan confronted him (2 Samuel 11 to 12). It is one of the seven penitential psalms. Augustine loved it so much that he had it written on the wall beside his bed when he was dying. Paul read it in Romans 4 as proof that David knew the blessing of being counted righteous apart from works.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no deceit" (v. 2).
3. "For when I kept silence, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long" (v. 3).
4. "For day and night your hand was heavy upon me; my strength was dried up as by the heat of summer" (v. 4).
5. "I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity" (v. 5).

6. “I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin” (v. 5).
7. “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you” (v. 8).
8. “Many are the sorrows of the wicked, but steadfast love surrounds the one who trusts in the LORD” (v. 10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a double beatitude: “Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered. Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity.” Three words for sin appear: transgression (rebellion), sin (missing the mark), and iniquity (twistedness). Three words for forgiveness answer them: forgiven (lifted away), covered, and not counted. Paul will pick up this last phrase, “counts no iniquity,” as the very meaning of justification. Notice that the blessing is not for the one who has never sinned, but for the one whose sin is dealt with.

Then David tells his story. He kept silence, hiding his sin. The result was physical and spiritual misery: his bones wasted away, he groaned all day, and God’s hand was heavy on him day and night. His strength dried up like a field in summer. Unconfessed sin is a heavy load, and the conscience is God’s instrument to press us toward him. Many people have lived with the weight of what they will not admit.

Then the turn: “I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity; I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin.” The sequence is short. David said he would confess, and God forgave. The speed of God’s forgiveness is striking. There is no penance or delay. The result is relief and safety: in a time of distress the rising waters will not reach him. The LORD becomes a hiding place.

God speaks in verse 8: “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you.” Forgiveness leads to guidance. And then a warning not to be like a horse or mule that needs bit and bridle to stay near. God would rather lead by relationship than force.

The psalm ends with a call to joy: “Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, you righteous, and shout for joy, all you upright in heart!” For Christians, the foundation of this joy is clearer than it was for David. Our sin was not simply passed over; it was covered by the blood of Christ. The one against whom the Lord counts no sin is the one who is in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 4:6-8 quotes verses 1-2. 2 Samuel 12:13 records Nathan's word, "The LORD has put away your sin." Psalm 51 is David's longer prayer after the same sin. Proverbs 28:13 says whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper. 1 John 1:5-10 teaches that if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive. James 5:16 tells us to confess to one another. Hebrews 4:16 invites us to the throne of grace. Psalm 103:10-12 says he removes our transgressions as far as the east is from the west.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes confessing specific sins to the LORD. Name them. Then thank him for forgiving.

If you are hiding something from God or from a trusted friend, bring it into the light.

Read the last verse aloud as a call to joy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Acknowledge your sin to God without covering it.
- Thank him for the forgiveness that makes you blessed.
- Ask him to be your hiding place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 733 · WEEK 105

Psalm 130

With him is plentiful redemption

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 130. It is a Song of Ascents and one of the penitential psalms. Notice how the psalm moves from the depths to hope, and what the psalmist waits for.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 130 was sung by pilgrims as they climbed to Jerusalem. Martin Luther loved it and called it one of the "Pauline psalms" because it teaches justification by grace as clearly as Paul does. It is only eight verses. John Wesley is said to have heard it sung at St. Paul's Cathedral on the afternoon of the day his heart was "strangely warmed" in 1738.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD!" (v. 1).
2. "O Lord, hear my voice! Let your ears be attentive to the voice of my pleas for mercy!" (v. 2).
3. "If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?" (v. 3).
4. "But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared" (v. 4).
5. "I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope" (v. 5).
6. "My soul waits for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning" (v. 6).
7. "For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption" (v. 7).
8. "And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins at the bottom: “Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD!” The depths are deep waters, a place of overwhelming trouble. The psalm makes clear that the deepest trouble is sin. The psalmist cries for mercy, aware that he has no claim on God.

The question in verse 3 is among the most searching in the Bible: “If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand?” The answer is no one. If God kept a record of every sin, no one would survive. This is Romans 3: none is righteous, no, not one. But the psalm turns on one word, “But.” “But with you there is forgiveness, that you may be feared.” The forgiveness is not a contradiction of God’s holiness. It is the result of his character. And the effect of forgiveness is not carelessness but reverence. The more we understand the cost of forgiveness, the more we fear God in the right way, with awe and love.

Next the psalmist waits. “I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in his word I hope.” He has no other support. He waits “more than watchmen for the morning,” repeated for emphasis. A night watchman on a city wall knows that morning will come, and longs for it. So the believer waits with certain hope for the LORD. Notice that hope is rooted in his word. The promises of God are the ground of waiting.

Then the psalmist turns to the whole community. “O Israel, hope in the LORD! For with the LORD there is steadfast love, and with him is plentiful redemption.” The word “plentiful” means abundant, overflowing. There is more redemption in God than sin in us. “And he will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.” All of them. For us, this promise has been fulfilled at the cross. Jesus’ name means “he will save his people from their sins” (Matthew 1:21). The plentiful redemption has been paid.

The psalm moves from the depths to the dawn. Many Christians have prayed it in seasons of guilt, depression, and delay. It teaches us that the way out of the depths is to cry to the LORD, to cling to his forgiveness, and to wait for him with hope.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 51 and Psalm 32 are other penitential psalms. Exodus 34:6-7 tells of the LORD who forgives iniquity. Micah 7:18-19 asks who is a God like you, pardoning iniquity. Isaiah 40:31 speaks of those who wait on the LORD. Lamentations 3:25-26 says the LORD is good to those who wait for him. Matthew 1:21 gives the meaning of Jesus’ name. Titus 2:14 says Christ gave himself to redeem us from all lawlessness. Ephesians 1:7 says we have redemption through his blood. 1 Peter 1:18-19 speaks of the precious blood of Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm if you are in a low place. If you are not, pray it for someone who is.

Wait on the LORD in one area today without rushing. Let his word be your hope.

Count the gifts of redemption you have received in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God out of the depths.
- Thank him that with him there is forgiveness and plentiful redemption.
- Wait for him and trust his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 734 · WEEK 105

Psalm 143:1-12

Enter not into judgment with your servant

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 143. It is the last of the penitential psalms. Paul alludes to verse 2 in Romans 3:20 and Galatians 2:16. Notice the combination of confession, longing, and request for guidance.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 143 is a prayer of David, perhaps from the time when Absalom pursued him. The enemy is real, but the deeper problem is that David knows that he cannot stand on his own merit before God. Verse 2 is the key line, and Paul used it to prove that no one is justified by works. With Psalms 32 and 130, it completes a trio on the theme of coming to God as a sinner.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear my prayer, O LORD; give ear to my pleas for mercy! In your faithfulness answer me, in your righteousness!” (v. 1).
2. “Enter not into judgment with your servant, for no one living is righteous before you” (v. 2).
3. “Therefore my spirit faints within me; my heart within me is appalled” (v. 4).
4. “I remember the days of old; I meditate on all that you have done; I ponder the work of your hands” (v. 5).
5. “I stretch out my hands to you; my soul thirsts for you like a parched land” (v. 6).
6. “Let me hear in the morning of your steadfast love, for in you I trust” (v. 8).
7. “Teach me to do your will, for you are my God! Let your good Spirit lead me on level ground!” (v. 10).

8 “For your name’s sake, O LORD, preserve my life! In your righteousness bring my soul out of trouble!” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David opens by appealing to God’s faithfulness and righteousness. This is unusual. Normally one might expect him to appeal to his own innocence. Instead he appeals to God’s character. He is asking God to act in keeping with his own promises. And then the line that Paul loves: “Enter not into judgment with your servant, for no one living is righteous before you.” David does not argue his case. He asks God not to bring him to court, because he would lose. This is the prayer of a man who understands that he is not righteous in himself. It is close to the cry of Romans 3.

The enemy has crushed David’s life to the ground, and he sits in darkness like those long dead. His spirit faints and his heart is appalled. This is an honest picture of despair, and the Bible does not hide it. What does David do? He remembers. “I remember the days of old; I meditate on all that you have done; I ponder the work of your hands.” When the present is dark, he looks at what God has done in the past. For Christians, the great work to remember is the cross and the resurrection.

He stretches out his hands, and his soul thirsts for God like parched land. Verses 7 to 10 are a series of brief requests: answer me quickly; let me hear of your steadfast love in the morning; make me know the way I should go; deliver me; teach me to do your will. Notice the order. First he asks to hear of God’s love, and then for guidance. We cannot follow God’s will without first resting in his love. And the prayer, “Let your good Spirit lead me on level ground,” anticipates the Spirit’s guidance for the believer.

The final plea rests on God’s name: “For your name’s sake, O LORD, preserve my life! In your righteousness bring my soul out of trouble.” David does not ask because he deserves it, but for the sake of God’s glory. In the end, he asks God to cut off his enemies, “for I am your servant.” The psalm ends with confidence in the relationship, not in himself.

How does this prepare us for Romans 5? We have just learned that no living person is righteous before God. The answer to David’s fear is the gospel: in Christ, God does enter into judgment, but he enters it on our behalf. The Judge himself has stood in the dock in our place.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:20 and Galatians 2:16 allude to verse 2. Psalm 51 and Psalm 130 are related. Job 9:2 and 25:4 also ask how a man can be righteous before God. Psalm 77:11-12 also speaks of remembering God's works. Psalm 63:1 is another thirst psalm. Romans 8:14 says all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. Nehemiah 9:20 says God gave his good Spirit to instruct. Hebrews 4:15-16 says we have a high priest who sympathizes with our weakness.

STEP 6

Application

Remember specific works of God in your life. Write down three.

Pray verse 8 tomorrow morning, before checking your phone: let me hear of your steadfast love.

Ask the Spirit to lead you on level ground, and listen for his answer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God not to enter into judgment with you, since no one living is righteous.
- Ask him to teach you to do his will.
- Ask him to lead you on level ground.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 105

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

DAY 735 · WEEK 105

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 3:23-24 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."

ROMANS 3:23-24

REST

Meditation

These two verses hold the whole gospel in a few lines. They tell the problem and the solution.

"For all have sinned." The word "all" leaves no exceptions. The Jew with the law and the Gentile without it, the moral and the immoral, the religious and the irreligious. No one is left out.

"And fall short of the glory of God." Sin is not only breaking rules. It is falling short of the purpose for which we were made: to reflect God's glory. We were made to image him, and we have failed.

"And are justified." Here is the turn. The word is a legal one: declared righteous, acquitted, accepted. This is God's verdict over those who believe.

"By his grace as a gift." Not by merit or effort, but freely. A gift cannot be earned, only received. Grace means undeserved favor, and the word "gift" underlines it.

“Through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.” Redemption means buying back, as a slave is ransomed. The price was the blood of Christ. All of this is “in Christ Jesus.” Outside of him there is no justification; in him there is no condemnation.

If you are tempted to think you are too bad to be forgiven, or good enough not to need it, say these verses. They fit both temptations.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw Paul’s verdict and the gospel that answers it. In Romans 3, every mouth was stopped: no one is righteous, and the law brings knowledge of sin. Then came the great “But now”: the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, and we are justified by grace as a gift, through the redemption in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood. In a doctrinal pause, you studied justification by faith alone: God declares sinners righteous because Christ’s righteousness is counted as theirs. Romans 4 used Abraham, who believed God and was counted righteous before circumcision and long before the law. Three psalms of repentance gave the heart’s side: Psalm 32, the blessing of the one whose sin is not counted; Psalm 130, with the LORD there is plentiful redemption; and Psalm 143, enter not into judgment with your servant.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which do you find harder to believe: that you are a sinner who cannot save yourself, or that you are fully forgiven and accepted in Christ? Why?

Paul says Jesus was put forward as a propitiation so that God could be both just and the justifier of the one who has faith. How does the cross show both God’s justice and God’s love at once?

David hid his sin and his bones wasted away, and then he confessed and was forgiven. Is there a sin you have been carrying in silence? What would it look like to confess it this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are justified by grace as a gift.

Rest in the work that Christ finished.

Tell him that you are not earning it.

DAY 736 · WEEK 106

Romans 5:1-21

Peace with God; Adam and Christ

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 5:1-21. The chapter moves from the benefits of justification to the way sin and grace work in history through two men, Adam and Christ. Read verses 1-11 for the experience of salvation, and 12-21 for the structure of salvation history.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 4 have shown that we are justified by faith. Chapter 5 begins with the word "Therefore." What follows from justification? First, peace, access, and hope. Then Paul steps back and places the whole human story in two heads: Adam, in whom all die, and Christ, in whom all who believe are made alive. This is a pivotal chapter for understanding how the covenants fit together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (5:1).
2. "And hope does not put us to shame, because God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us" (5:5).
3. "But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (5:8).
4. "For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son, much more, now that we are reconciled, shall we be saved by his life" (5:10).
5. "Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned" (5:12).

6. “Adam, who was a type of the one who was to come” (5:14).
7. “For as by the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man’s obedience the many will be made righteous” (5:19).
8. “But where sin increased, grace abounded all the more” (5:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God.” This is peace as a status, an end to hostility. We were enemies, and now we are at peace. We have access by faith into the grace in which we stand, and we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God. Paul even says we rejoice in our sufferings, because suffering produces endurance, endurance character, and character hope. And hope does not disappoint us because God’s love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit. Notice that all three persons of the Trinity are active: peace with God the Father through the Son, and the Spirit pouring love into our hearts.

The proof of God’s love is the cross. “While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” We were weak, ungodly, sinners, and enemies. Few would die for a righteous man, though perhaps for a good man someone would dare. But Christ died for the ungodly. And Paul reasons from the greater to the lesser: if God did the hard thing while we were enemies, he will do the easy thing now that we are reconciled. We will be saved from the wrath through him. We rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received reconciliation.

Then comes the great comparison, from verse 12. Sin entered the world through one man, Adam, and death through sin, so death spread to all because all sinned. This does not simply mean that Adam set a bad example. Adam acted as the head of the human race, and what he did had consequences for all who were in him. Christians have explained the details differently: some hold that Adam’s guilt is directly counted to us (the federal headship view), others that we inherit a corrupt nature and then sin ourselves. All agree that sin and death came through Adam and cannot be escaped by our own efforts. Paul calls Adam “a type of the one who was to come.”

Christ is the second Adam. The parallel is not exact: the free gift is not like the trespass. If many died through one man’s trespass, much more have the grace of God and the free gift by the grace of the one man Jesus Christ abounded for many. As one trespass led to condemnation for all, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life. The point is stated plainly: “as by the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man’s obedience the many will be made righteous.”

Where did the law fit in? It came in to increase the trespass, to show the true nature of sin, "but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more, so that, as sin reigned in death, grace also might reign through righteousness leading to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord." Grace wins. Grace is stronger than sin.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2 to 3 is the account of Adam and the fall. 1 Corinthians 15:21-22 and 15:45-49 contrast Adam and Christ. Luke 3:38 and Luke 4 show Jesus as the second Adam, tested in the wilderness. Hebrews 2:5-18 speaks of Christ as the true Man. Colossians 1:19-22 speaks of reconciliation. 2 Corinthians 5:18-21 is the ministry of reconciliation. Ephesians 2:1-10 describes our being made alive. Isaiah 53:11 says the righteous one will make many to be accounted righteous. 1 John 4:10 says love consists in that he loved us and sent his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Count your suffering as a means God uses to build hope. Is there an area where you can see this?

Meditate on Romans 5:8 today. Let it silence your doubts about God's love.

Thank Jesus for being the second Adam, who obeyed where Adam failed.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for peace with him through Jesus.
- Thank him for pouring his love into your heart by the Spirit.
- Thank him for loving you while you were a sinner.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 737 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-14; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:4-10

Union with Christ

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-14, Galatians 2:20, and Ephesians 2:4-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on union with Christ. Notice the repeated phrase “with him” and “in Christ,” and how the believer’s past, present, and future are bound to his.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

If we are justified by grace and where sin increased grace abounded all the more, a person might ask: why not keep sinning so that grace may increase? Paul replies with horror, “By no means!” and gives his answer: a believer cannot go on living in sin, because he has been united to Christ in his death and resurrection. Union with Christ is the deepest category of the Christian life. John Calvin said that Christ and all his benefits come to us through union with him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?” (Romans 6:3).
2. “We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in newness of life” (Romans 6:4).
3. “For if we have been united with him in a death like his, we shall certainly be united with him in a resurrection like his” (Romans 6:5).
4. “We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to nothing, so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin” (Romans 6:6).

5. “So you also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus” (Romans 6:11).
6. “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Galatians 2:20).
7. “And raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus” (Ephesians 2:6).
8. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God” (Ephesians 2:8).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Union with Christ means that every believer is joined to Christ by the Spirit through faith, so that what is true of him becomes true of us. The New Testament expresses this in phrases such as “in Christ,” “with Christ,” and “Christ in you,” which appear well over a hundred times. This is not a mere figure of speech. It is a real, spiritual, and personal bond. Paul uses images: a body and its head, a vine and its branches, a husband and wife, a building and its cornerstone.

Union with Christ is the source of every saving benefit. Justification: we are counted righteous because we are in him. Sanctification: we are changed because we share his death and resurrection life. Adoption: we are sons because we are in the Son. Perseverance: nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus. And glorification: we will be raised as he was raised. It also shows why the gospel is not only forgiveness but a new life. In Romans 6, the believer’s old self was crucified with Christ, and he now walks in newness of life. The old master, sin, has lost its dominion.

Notice the three tenses of union with Christ. We have died with him (past). We now live to God in him (present). We will be raised with him (future). In Ephesians 2, Paul speaks of the future as already done: God “raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places.” Our life is hidden with Christ in God (Colossians 3:3).

Christians differ on whether “baptized into Christ” in Romans 6:3 refers primarily to water baptism, or to the Spirit’s baptism that joins us to Christ, which water baptism pictures. Baptists and Presbyterians also differ about who should be baptized and how. All agree that baptism points to the union with Christ in his death and resurrection that is received by faith.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul's question, "Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound?" is answered, "By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" The believer's relationship to sin has been broken, not because he has become sinless, but because he has died. He now belongs to another.

"Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death?" Paul assumes that every Christian knows this. Baptism pictures union: we go under with Christ in death and come up with him in resurrection. The purpose is clear: "that we too might walk in newness of life." The Christian life is not a self-improvement program. It is a resurrection life.

The logic is expressed in verses 5 to 7: "If we have been united with him in a death like his, we shall certainly be united with him in a resurrection like his." The "old self," the person we were in Adam, was crucified with Christ. The result is not perfection, but freedom: we are no longer slaves to sin. "For one who has died has been set free from sin." And then comes the command, in three steps. First "consider": "You also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus." Count it true. Then, "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body." Finally, present yourselves to God. The commands are built on the indicatives. We obey because of who we are in Christ.

Galatians 2:20 is the personal confession: "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." Notice the final clause. Paul's identity is bound up with Christ's love and self-giving.

Ephesians 2 sets the same truth in a wider frame. We were dead in trespasses, but God, being rich in mercy, made us alive together with Christ, raised us up with him, and seated us with him in the heavenly places. Why? "So that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus." And it is all of grace: "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God."

STEP 5

Connection

John 15:1-8 is the vine and the branches. Colossians 2:11-13 and 3:1-4 speak of being buried and raised with Christ. 2 Corinthians 5:17 says if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. 1 Corinthians 12:12-13 describes the body of Christ. Ephesians 1:3-14 lists the blessings "in

Christ." Ephesians 5:25-32 speaks of the mystery of Christ and the church. Galatians 3:26-29 says all are one in Christ Jesus. Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus. 2 Peter 1:4 speaks of sharing in the divine nature.

STEP 6

Application

Say the word "consider" to yourself today when you are tempted: consider yourself dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus.

Read Galatians 2:20 aloud and make it your own confession.

Think about baptism, yours or someone else's, as a picture of union with Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that in Christ you have died to sin and been raised to new life.
- Ask him to help you live in that union.
- Tell him where you are tempted to live as if it were not true.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 738 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-23

Dead to sin, alive to God; slaves of righteousness

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-23. You studied the first half of this chapter in the doctrinal pause on union with Christ. Today read the whole chapter, and focus on the language of slavery and freedom in verses 15-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that believers have died to sin. In the second half of chapter 6, he uses the picture of slavery to explain the change of masters. Everyone serves something. The question is not whether we will be slaves but whose. Paul's readers in Rome knew slavery well, and the image was both vivid and humbling.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What shall we say then? Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound?" (6:1).
2. "By no means! How can we who died to sin still live in it?" (6:2).
3. "For one who has died has been set free from sin" (6:7).
4. "Present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life" (6:13).
5. "But thanks be to God, that you who were once slaves of sin have become obedient from the heart to the standard of teaching to which you were committed" (6:17).
6. "And, having been set free from sin, have become slaves of righteousness" (6:18).
7. "But now that you have been set free from sin and have become slaves of God, the fruit you get leads to sanctification and its end, eternal life" (6:22).
8. "For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord" (6:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter opens with an objection that Paul takes very seriously. If grace is free, why not sin more? The answer in the first half is union with Christ. In the second half, Paul adds a second argument: the idea of two masters.

In verses 12 to 14, he gives practical commands. “Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its passions.” Sin is a king. It still tries to rule. Do not present your members, hands, eyes, tongue, to sin as instruments of unrighteousness, but present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life. And the promise: “Sin will have no dominion over you, since you are not under law but under grace.” Grace is not a license, but a power.

Then the second question: “Are we to sin because we are not under law but under grace? By no means!” Paul turns to slavery. “Do you not know that if you present yourselves to anyone as obedient slaves, you are slaves of the one whom you obey, either of sin, which leads to death, or of obedience, which leads to righteousness?” There is no neutral ground. We are slaves of sin or slaves of righteousness. But the change has happened: “Thanks be to God, that you who were once slaves of sin have become obedient from the heart to the standard of teaching to which you were committed.” The gospel has teaching, and obedience from the heart is the evidence of conversion.

The paradox is that serving God is freedom. Slavery to sin offers apparent liberty but delivers shame: “What fruit were you getting at that time from the things of which you are now ashamed? For the end of those things is death.” Slavery to God yields fruit that leads to sanctification and its end, eternal life. The believer’s obedience is not a way to earn salvation, but a growing holiness that expresses it.

The chapter ends with one of the best-known verses of Romans: “For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Wages are earned; a gift is not. Sin pays what it owes: death. God gives what we have not earned: eternal life. And it is found only “in Christ Jesus our Lord.” The verse sums up the whole letter so far.

STEP 5

Connection

John 8:34-36 says everyone who commits sin is a slave to sin, but the Son sets free. Galatians 5:1 says for freedom Christ has set us free. 1 Peter 2:16 calls us to live as people who are free, yet servants of God. Matthew 6:24 says no one can serve two masters. Ephesians 2:1-3 describes our former life. 2 Timothy 2:19 speaks of departing from iniquity. Titus 2:11-14 speaks of grace training us to renounce ungodliness. Genesis 2:17 and Ezekiel 18:20 speak of death as the wage of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what has been mastering you. Name the idol, habit, or fear that most often rules your decisions.

Present yourself to God today. Give him your hands, your eyes, and your tongue for one task.

Memorize Romans 6:23 and share it with a friend.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for setting you free from sin.

Offer yourself to him as an instrument of righteousness, and name one way.

Ask him not to let sin reign in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 739 · WEEK 106

Romans 7:1-25

The law's limits; the wretched man's cry

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 7:1-25. This is one of the most debated chapters in the Bible. Read verses 1-6 on being released from the law, verses 7-13 on the law and sin, and verses 14-25 on the struggle. Notice the cry in verse 24 and the answer in verse 25.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has said that believers are not under law but under grace (6:14). A listener might ask, "Is the law then sin?" Chapter 7 answers. The law is holy, righteous, and good, but it cannot save or sanctify, because it meets a heart already enslaved to sin. The chapter ends with the cry of a man who sees the war within himself. Christians have argued for centuries about who this "I" is.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Likewise, my brothers, you also have died to the law through the body of Christ, so that you may belong to another, to him who has been raised from the dead, in order that we may bear fruit for God" (7:4).
2. "What shall we say then? That the law is sin? By no means! Yet if it had not been for the law, I would not have known sin" (7:7).
3. "So then, the law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good" (7:12).
4. "For I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate" (7:15).
5. "For I know that nothing good dwells in me, that is, in my flesh" (7:18).
6. "For I delight in the law of God, in my inner being" (7:22).

7. “Wretched man that I am! Who will deliver me from this body of death?” (7:24).
8. “Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!” (7:25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with an illustration from marriage. A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives; if he dies, she is free to marry another. In the same way, believers have “died to the law through the body of Christ, so that you may belong to another, to him who has been raised from the dead.” The goal is fruit for God. Before, “our sinful passions, aroused by the law, were at work in our members to bear fruit for death.” Now we serve “in the new way of the Spirit and not in the old way of the written code.” This is the contrast between the old covenant and the new, a key idea in the progressive covenantal reading: the Mosaic covenant has served its purpose and been fulfilled in Christ.

Is the law then to blame? “By no means!” The law shows what sin is. Paul uses the tenth commandment, “You shall not covet,” as an example. Sin took the opportunity in the commandment to produce all kinds of covetousness. “So the law is holy, and the commandment is holy and righteous and good.” The problem is not the law but sin, which uses the good law to show its evil.

Then, from verse 14, Paul shifts into the present tense and speaks of a deep inner conflict. “I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate.” “I have the desire to do what is right, but not the ability to carry it out.” “I delight in the law of God, in my inner being, but I see in my members another law waging war against the law of my mind.” He cries: “Wretched man that I am! Who will deliver me from this body of death?” And the answer: “Thanks be to God through Jesus Christ our Lord!”

Who is this speaker? Faithful interpreters differ. Some (Augustine in his later writings, Luther, Calvin, and many Reformed writers) see the regenerate Christian, because the speaker delights in God’s law and hates sin, which an unbeliever would not. Others (Origen, and many modern scholars) see Paul describing the person under the law before Christ, or Israel under Sinai, speaking in the first person for dramatic effect. Both agree on the main point: the law cannot rescue, and only Christ can. Both also agree that the believer’s experience includes a real struggle with remaining sin (Galatians 5:17). The cry of verse 24 is not the last word. Chapter 8 begins, “There is therefore now no condemnation.”

If you have felt this conflict, you are not strange. It is evidence that something has changed, that you want what is good. The answer is not to try harder but to look to the deliverer.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 20:17 is the tenth commandment. Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Ezekiel 36:26-27 promise the new covenant. Galatians 5:16-24 describes the war between flesh and Spirit. Galatians 3:19-25 explains the purpose of the law as a guardian until Christ. 2 Corinthians 3:4-18 contrasts the old and new covenants. Hebrews 8:6-13 says the new covenant is better. Psalm 119 shows delight in the law. 1 John 1:8-2:2 deals with remaining sin and our advocate.

STEP 6

Application

Name an area where you do what you do not want. Bring it to Christ, not just to your willpower.

Say verse 25 aloud as an answer to your own wretchedness.

Thank God that the law is holy, and that Christ has done what the law could not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you do what you hate and fail to do what you want.
- Cry, “Wretched man that I am,” and thank him for Jesus.
- Thank him that there is now no condemnation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

“But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.”

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 740 · WEEK 106

Romans 6:1-14; 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8; Philippians 2:12-13

Sanctification

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 6:1-14, 1 Thessalonians 4:1-8, and Philippians 2:12-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on sanctification: how God makes believers holy. Notice who acts and what the believer is told to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After chapters on justification and a chapter on the war within, Romans moves toward the Spirit's work in chapter 8. Today we pause to ask: if we are justified by faith alone, how does a Christian grow? The New Testament uses the word sanctification to describe the process of being made holy, set apart for God and conformed to the image of Christ. Paul wrote to the Thessalonians, a young church in a pagan city, to urge them to live in holiness. And to the Philippians he gave the famous pairing of God's work and ours.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, to make you obey its passions" (Romans 6:12).
2. "But present yourselves to God as those who have been brought from death to life" (Romans 6:13).
3. "For sin will have no dominion over you, since you are not under law but under grace" (Romans 6:14).
4. "That, as you received from us how you ought to walk and to please God, just as you are doing, you do so more and more" (1 Thessalonians 4:1).

5. “For this is the will of God, your sanctification” (1 Thessalonians 4:3).
6. “For God has not called us for impurity, but in holiness” (1 Thessalonians 4:7).
7. “Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling” (Philippians 2:12).
8. “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (Philippians 2:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Sanctification is the work of God by which he makes believers holy. The Bible speaks of it in three ways. First, definitive sanctification: at conversion, every believer is set apart for God. Paul calls the Corinthians “sanctified in Christ Jesus” even while he rebukes them (1 Corinthians 1:2). Second, progressive sanctification: throughout life, the Spirit conforms us to Christ, so that we put to death the old ways and grow in love, joy, peace, patience, and the rest of the fruit of the Spirit. Third, final sanctification: when Christ returns, we will be made perfectly like him (1 John 3:2).

The key to Philippians 2:12-13 is that both are true at once. “Work out your own salvation” does not mean earn it; it means carry it into every area of life. And the reason is: “for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work.” God’s work does not replace ours; it empowers it. We are active, but we are not alone. This is why Christians pray, read, fight sin, and serve, and then give God the credit.

Sanctification differs from justification. Justification is a legal declaration, once for all and complete, while sanctification is a lifelong process that is never completed in this life. Justification is wholly God’s act, while in sanctification we cooperate by the Spirit’s power. But they cannot be separated. Everyone whom God justifies, he sanctifies. Holiness is not a condition for being accepted; it is the fruit of being accepted.

The ordinary means of sanctification are the word of God, prayer, the fellowship of the church, the Lord’s Supper, and suffering. Christians differ about whether believers can reach a state of entire sanctification or sinless perfection in this life. Wesleyans hold that perfect love is possible; Reformed Christians hold that sin remains until death while the Spirit’s work grows. All agree that the call to holiness is real and urgent, and that no one can see the Lord without it (Hebrews 12:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Romans 6:12-14, Paul uses commands that rest on the facts of union with Christ. Do not let sin reign. Do not offer your members to sin. Offer yourselves to God. The ground of obedience is grace: "You are not under law but under grace." The law could command but not empower. Grace both forgives and strengthens. This is why the New Testament never treats holiness as a condition of salvation but always as its result.

In 1 Thessalonians 4, Paul writes to young believers who have turned from idols. "This is the will of God, your sanctification: that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each of you know how to control his own body in holiness and honor, not in the passion of lust like the Gentiles who do not know God." Sanctification is concrete. It touches our bodies, our habits, our relationships. And Paul adds that "God has not called us for impurity, but in holiness. Therefore whoever disregards this, disregards not man but God, who gives his Holy Spirit to you." The Spirit is the Holy Spirit, and he is the one who makes us holy. Notice that Paul urges them to do this "more and more." Growth is expected.

The pairing in Philippians 2 is the most balanced summary. "Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling." The phrase conveys reverence, not terror. And then the encouragement: God is the one at work in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure. Even the desire to obey is his gift. This should keep us from pride when we obey and from despair when we fail.

So what do you do? Fight sin by the Spirit, using the means of grace. Remember who you are in Christ. Confess when you fall, and get up. And trust the one who began a good work in you to bring it to completion (Philippians 1:6).

STEP 5

Connection

1 Corinthians 1:2 and 6:11 speak of being sanctified. John 17:17 is Jesus' prayer, "Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth." Romans 8:13 says by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body. Galatians 5:16-25 describes walking by the Spirit. 2 Corinthians 3:18 says we are being transformed into the same image. Hebrews 12:1-14 speaks of strife toward holiness. 1 Peter 1:13-16 calls us to be holy as he is holy. 1 John 3:2-3 gives the final hope. Ezekiel 36:27 promises the Spirit to cause us to walk in his statutes.

STEP 6

Application

Choose one specific area of obedience to work on this week. Ask the Spirit for help, and tell someone who will ask you about it.

When you obey, thank God. When you fail, confess and move on. Neither pride nor despair.

Read Philippians 1:6 as an encouragement that God will finish what he began.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for setting you apart in Christ.

Ask him to work in you both to will and to work for his good pleasure.

Tell him where you want to grow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 741 · WEEK 106

Romans 8:1-39

No condemnation; the Spirit; nothing separates us

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:1-39. Many Christians call this the greatest chapter in the Bible. Read it slowly, perhaps in two sittings: verses 1-17 on life in the Spirit, and verses 18-39 on suffering, glory, and the love of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 7 ended with the cry "Wretched man that I am!" Chapter 8 begins with the answer: no condemnation. The Holy Spirit, mentioned only a few times in the first seven chapters, appears nearly twenty times here. The chapter moves from the Spirit's work within, to the groaning of creation, to the unbreakable love of God. It is a summit of the Bible, and many believers have memorized it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (8:1).
2. "You, however, are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if in fact the Spirit of God dwells in you" (8:9).
3. "For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, Abba! Father!" (8:15).
4. "For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us" (8:18).
5. "And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose" (8:28).
6. "If God is for us, who can be against us?" (8:31).

7. “He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?” (8:32).

8. “Nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord” (8:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” The word “now” is emphatic: the verdict is already given. The reason: “the law of the Spirit of life has set you free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death.” What the law could not do, weakened by the flesh, God did: by sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh. The condemnation fell on Christ so that none falls on us. And the result is that the righteous requirement of the law is fulfilled in us, who walk according to the Spirit.

Verses 5 to 11 contrast two ways of living: the mind set on the flesh is death, and the mind set on the Spirit is life and peace. Every Christian has the Spirit: “Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him.” And the Spirit who raised Jesus from the dead will give life to our mortal bodies. The resurrection is already at work in us.

Verses 12 to 17 speak of adoption. We are not debtors to the flesh. By the Spirit we put to death the deeds of the body. All who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God. The Spirit does not make us fearful slaves but sons who cry “Abba! Father!” (an Aramaic word of intimate address). The Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs, fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him so that we may also be glorified with him.

Verses 18 to 27 deal with suffering. The present sufferings are not worth comparing with the coming glory. Creation itself waits with eager longing, subjected to futility, groaning as in the pains of childbirth. We also groan, waiting for adoption, the redemption of our bodies. “In this hope we were saved.” And the Spirit helps us in our weakness: “We do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words.”

Then the golden chain. “We know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose.” This is not that all things are good, but that God works all things for the good of his people, and the good is defined in verse 29: to be conformed to the image of his Son. “For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son… and those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.” Notice

that the chain has no broken links. Everyone who is justified will be glorified. Christians differ about the meaning of "foreknew": Reformed readers hold that it means God set his love on them beforehand, while others hold that it refers to God's foreknowledge of their faith. All agree that salvation is secured by God's purpose.

Paul ends with a series of questions that no one can answer against us. "If God is for us, who can be against us?" "He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" "Who shall bring any charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies." "Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died, more than that, who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us." "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?" Not tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, or sword. "In all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us." And the closing: "neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 5:1-11 anticipates the confidence of this chapter. John 14:15-17 and 16:7-15 promise the Spirit. Galatians 4:4-7 also speaks of the Spirit of adoption. Genesis 3:17-19 explains why creation groans. Isaiah 65:17-25 and Revelation 21:1-5 promise a new creation. Ephesians 1:3-14 speaks of election and the Spirit as a seal. Philippians 1:6 and John 10:28-29 assure perseverance. Psalm 44:22 is quoted in verse 36. Hebrews 7:25 says Christ always lives to make intercession for us. 1 John 4:9-10 speaks of God's love in sending his Son.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 1 aloud, and put your name in it: there is now no condemnation for me.

Name a present suffering. Compare it to the glory to come, as Paul does, without minimizing the pain.

Memorize verses 38 and 39. Say them when you wake in the night.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that there is now no condemnation for you in Christ.

Thank him for the Spirit of adoption who lets you cry, “Abba, Father.”

Tell him what you want to be sure cannot separate you from his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 106

“But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.”

ROMANS 5:8

DAY 742 · WEEK 106

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 5:8 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

ROMANS 5:8

REST

Meditation

This verse is the center of the gospel in a single sentence.

"But God shows his love for us." The verse begins with a contrast. The previous verses spoke of how rare it is for anyone to die for another. "But God." His love is a different kind of love. The word "shows" means to demonstrate or prove. The cross is God's own demonstration of his love.

"In that while we were still sinners." Notice the timing. Not after we cleaned up, or when we decided to follow him. We were still sinners, still enemies, still without strength. God's love does not wait for us to be lovable.

"Christ died for us." Here is the proof. God did not simply declare love; he acted at great cost. Christ died, and he died "for us," in our place and for our benefit.

This verse is not just history; it is the foundation for security. If God loved us when we were sinners, how much more will he keep us now that we are his children (5:9-10)? Our assurance does not rest on our record but on his demonstration.

When you doubt that God loves you, say this verse. The cross is the answer.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw what flows from justification. Romans 5 began with peace with God, access to grace, and hope that does not put us to shame, and then traced our story in two heads: Adam, through whom sin and death came, and Christ, through whom the free gift of righteousness and life comes. A doctrinal pause on union with Christ showed that believers have died and risen with him. Romans 6 answered the charge that grace encourages sin: we were slaves of sin and have become slaves of righteousness, and the wages of sin is death but the free gift of God is eternal life. Romans 7 gave the struggle with the law and the cry of the wretched man, answered by Jesus Christ our Lord. A second doctrinal pause considered sanctification, in which God works in us both to will and to work. Then Romans 8 opened with no condemnation and closed with the unbreakable love of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says God showed his love for us while we were still sinners. How does it change you to know that God's love did not wait for you to improve?

Romans 5 says that in Adam all died and in Christ all who believe are made righteous. Where do you still try to live as if you were under Adam's headship, relying on yourself?

Romans 8:1 says there is now no condemnation. Which voice do you hear most often, the voice of condemnation or the voice of the Spirit? What would it take to listen to the second?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for dying for you while you were still a sinner.

Ask him to silence the voice of condemnation.

Rest in his love.

DAY 743 · WEEK 107

Romans 9:1–33

God's sovereign election; Israel and the promise

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 33 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 9:1-33. This chapter begins three chapters (9 to 11) on God's purposes for Israel. Read it prayerfully, noting Paul's sorrow, his focus on God's mercy, and the question of who belongs to Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Romans 8 ended with the certainty that nothing can separate believers from God's love. A Jewish reader might object: if God's promises to Israel have failed, how can we trust his promises to us? Paul takes up this question in chapters 9 to 11. Chapter 9 explains that God's word has not failed, because the promise always worked by election, not by physical descent. This chapter has been argued over for centuries, and it deserves careful and humble reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart" (9:2).
2. "To them belong the adoption, the glory, the covenants, the giving of the law, the worship, and the promises" (9:4).
3. "But it is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel" (9:6).
4. "For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion" (9:15).
5. "So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy" (9:16).
6. "But who are you, O man, to answer back to God?" (9:20).

7. “Those who were not my people I will call my people, and her who was not beloved I will call beloved” (9:25).

8. “Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone of stumbling, and a rock of offense; and whoever believes in him will not be put to shame” (9:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with grief. “I am speaking the truth in Christ… I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart. For I could wish that I myself were accursed and cut off from Christ for the sake of my brothers.” Like Moses, who asked to be blotted out for the sake of the people (Exodus 32:32), Paul loves his people so much that he would give up his own salvation if it could save them. This is the heart of a missionary. Any teaching of election that does not produce this kind of love has missed the point.

He lists Israel’s privileges: adoption, glory, covenants, the law, worship, promises, patriarchs, and “from their race, according to the flesh, is the Christ, who is God over all, blessed forever.” This is one of the clearest statements of Christ’s deity.

Then the key claim: “It is not as though the word of God has failed. For not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel.” The true Israel was always defined by God’s promise, not by physical descent. Isaac, not Ishmael. Jacob, not Esau, chosen “though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad, in order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls.” “Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated,” a Hebrew idiom of preference, citing Malachi 1:2-3.

Paul anticipates the objection: “Is there injustice on God’s part? By no means!” He cites Moses: “I will have mercy on whom I have mercy.” Salvation “depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy.” Pharaoh is the example of one who was hardened, so that God’s power might be shown. The potter and the clay: “Who are you, O man, to answer back to God?” God has the right to show wrath and make known his power, and to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, “whom he has prepared beforehand for glory, even us whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles.”

Christians differ on how to read this chapter. Reformed interpreters see individual election to salvation: God sovereignly chooses those he will save. Others (Arminian and many other evangelicals) read the chapter as corporate election, focused on groups and on God’s purposes in history, or hold that God elects in view of foreseen faith. Everyone agrees on what Paul emphasizes: salvation is wholly by God’s mercy, and no one has a claim on him.

And the chapter closes by returning to faith. Gentiles who did not pursue righteousness attained it by faith; Israel pursued it by works and stumbled over the stone. Whoever believes in him will not be put to shame.

Do not use this chapter as a place to argue. Use it as a place to worship. If you are saved, it is because God had mercy on you.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 21:12 and 25:23 are the stories of Isaac and Jacob. Exodus 9:16, 33:19 and 4 to 14 tell of Pharaoh and Moses. Malachi 1:2-3 is quoted in verse 13. Isaiah 29:16 and Jeremiah 18:1-6 are the potter and the clay. Hosea 1:10 and 2:23 are quoted in verses 25 to 26. Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16 speak of the stone. Ephesians 1:4-5 and 2:8-9 speak of choice and grace. 1 Peter 2:4-10 says Christ is the cornerstone. John 6:37-44 teaches that the Father draws people. 2 Peter 3:9 says God is patient, not wishing that any should perish.

STEP 6

Application

Let this chapter humble you rather than divide you. Thank God for his mercy to you, which you did not earn.

Pray for people of Jewish background, and for your friends who do not believe, with the kind of anguish Paul had.

Ask whether you question God's right to rule. Where do you answer back?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you were not beloved and he called you beloved.
- Tell him what you cannot understand about his choosing, and trust him.
- Ask him to make you humble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 744 · WEEK 107

Romans 10:1-11:36

Faith from hearing; the mystery of Israel; doxology

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 10:1-11:36. This is a long reading, so take it in two parts: chapter 10 on faith that comes from hearing, and chapter 11 on God's plan for Israel and the Gentiles. End with the doxology in 11:33-36.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapter 9 stressed God's sovereign choice. Chapter 10 emphasizes human responsibility: Israel's problem is that they did not submit to God's righteousness, and the message is open to all who call. Chapter 11 asks the question that remains: has God rejected his people? Paul's answer reveals a mystery of God's plan across history, and it ends with one of the great praise passages in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes" (10:4).
2. "Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (10:9).
3. "So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ" (10:17).
4. "I ask, then, has God rejected his people? By no means!" (11:1).
5. "So too at the present time there is a remnant, chosen by grace" (11:5).
6. "And in this way all Israel will be saved" (11:26).
7. "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!" (11:33).

8 “For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen” (11:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with prayer: “Brothers, my heart’s desire and prayer to God for them is that they may be saved.” He admits they have zeal for God, but not according to knowledge. Being ignorant of the righteousness of God, and seeking to establish their own, they did not submit. “For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to everyone who believes.” The word “end” can mean goal or termination. Probably both: Christ is the goal toward which the law pointed, and its termination as a way of righteousness.

The message of faith is near: “The word is near you, in your mouth and in your heart.” And the heart of it: “If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes and is justified, and with the mouth one confesses and is saved.” The confession is “Jesus is Lord,” the earliest creed, and it is joined with belief in the resurrection. It is for everyone: “There is no distinction between Jew and Greek; for the same Lord is Lord of all, bestowing his riches on all who call on him. For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

Then the chain of missions: “How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard? And how are they to hear without someone preaching? And how are they to preach unless they are sent? As it is written, How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!” This passage has sent generations of missionaries. “So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” Israel has heard but not obeyed. God has held out his hands to a disobedient and contrary people.

In chapter 11, Paul asks: has God rejected his people? “By no means! For I myself am an Israelite.” God has not rejected the people whom he foreknew. There is a remnant, chosen by grace: like the seven thousand in Elijah’s day. Others were hardened, but their stumbling has meant salvation for the Gentiles, to make Israel jealous.

Paul warns the Gentile believers with the picture of the olive tree. Branches were broken off because of unbelief, and wild olive branches (Gentiles) were grafted in. “Remember it is not you who support the root, but the root that supports you.” Do not be arrogant. And the broken-off branches can be grafted in again if they do not continue in unbelief.

Then the mystery: “A partial hardening has come upon Israel, until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in. And in this way all Israel will be saved.” Christians disagree about what “all Israel” means. Some think it refers to the whole elect people of God, Jew and Gentile

together. Others think it means the ethnic nation of Israel, who will turn to Christ in large numbers before or at the end. Others hold that it means the elect of Israel throughout history. All agree that God's gifts and calling are irrevocable, that he will be faithful to his promises, and that salvation for both Jew and Gentile comes only through faith in Christ.

The long argument ends not with a conclusion but with praise. "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways! For who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his counselor? Or who has given a gift to him that he might be repaid? For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen." When theology reaches its limit, it turns to worship.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 30:11-14 is quoted in 10:6-8. Joel 2:32 is quoted in verse 13. Isaiah 52:7 is quoted in verse 15. Isaiah 53:1 is quoted in verse 16. Deuteronomy 32:21 and Isaiah 65:1-2 are quoted in 10:19-21. 1 Kings 19:10-18 is the story of the seven thousand. Jeremiah 11:16-17 and Hosea 14:6 use the olive tree. Ephesians 2:11-22 speaks of Jew and Gentile made one. Galatians 6:16 mentions the Israel of God. Isaiah 40:13 is quoted in 11:34. Job 41:11 is quoted in verse 35. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the worshiping multitude.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Romans 10:9 and share it with someone this week.

Pray for someone to be sent to those who have not heard. Consider how you can support missions.

Let the doxology in 11:33-36 be your prayer after a difficult question.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess Jesus as Lord with your mouth and tell him you believe God raised him.
- Pray for someone to hear and believe.
- Praise God for the depth of his wisdom.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 745 · WEEK 107

Psalm 19:1-6

The heavens declare, creation's speech

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 19:1-6. Paul quotes verse 4 in Romans 10:18. Read these six verses as a picture of creation's wordless sermon, and think about why Paul says it is not enough.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David in two parts. Verses 1 to 6 celebrate God's revelation in creation, and verses 7 to 14 celebrate his revelation in the law. C. S. Lewis called it among the greatest poems in the Psalter. In Romans 10, Paul has just asked, "Have they not heard?" and answers with verse 4 of this psalm: their voice has gone out to all the earth. Today we read the creation half in light of Romans.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard" (v. 3).
4. "Their voice goes out through all the earth, and their words to the end of the world" (v. 4).
5. "In them he has set a tent for the sun" (v. 4).
6. "Which comes out like a bridegroom leaving his chamber" (v. 5).
7. "And, like a strong man, runs its course with joy" (v. 5).
8. "And there is nothing hidden from its heat" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a grand claim: “The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.” Creation is a witness. The verbs, declare, proclaim, pour out speech, reveal knowledge, are all verbs of speaking. Day after day, night after night, creation preaches. The sky is God’s billboard, and its message is his glory.

Yet verse 3 adds a paradox: “There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard.” The sermon has no words, and yet its voice goes out through all the earth. The message is universal. This is why Paul says in Romans 1:20 that no one has an excuse: God’s eternal power and divine nature have been clearly perceived in the things that have been made. Look up at the stars and you see something of the majesty of the one who made them.

The second half of this section uses the sun as an example. God has set a tent for the sun, and it comes out “like a bridegroom leaving his chamber, and, like a strong man, runs its course with joy.” Its circuit goes from one end of the heavens to the other, and nothing is hidden from its heat. The sun is a great picture of a creature that obeys its Maker: radiant, joyful, regular. It is also a picture of the reach of God’s revelation.

Paul quotes verse 4 in Romans 10:18, but notice how. He has argued that faith comes from hearing the word of Christ. He asks, “Have they not heard?” and answers, “Indeed they have, for their voice has gone out to all the earth, and their words to the ends of the world.” Some interpreters think Paul is using the language of Psalm 19 to describe the reach of the gospel preached by the apostles, as the sun’s light reaches everywhere. Others think he is saying that the witness of creation alone leaves everyone accountable. Either way, the point is that general revelation cannot save. Creation shows God’s glory, but only the gospel shows how sinners can be made right with him. That is why the psalm turns, in verse 7, to the law of the LORD, which is perfect, reviving the soul.

Next time you look at the sky, let it point to its maker. Then open your Bible and learn the rest of the story.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 8 and Psalm 104 also celebrate creation. Job 38 to 41 is God’s speech from the whirlwind. Isaiah 40:26 invites us to lift up our eyes and see who created these. Romans 1:19-20 and 10:18 draw from this psalm. Acts 14:17 and 17:24-28 speak of God’s witness in nature. Colossians 1:23 speaks of the gospel proclaimed in all creation. John 1:1-5 speaks of the Word through whom all things were made. Revelation 21:23 says the city has no need of sun or moon, for the Lamb is its light.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside today and look at the sky, day or night. Let it declare the glory of God to you.

Thank God for the sun, which rises each day on his command.

Pray for someone who has only creation's witness and has never heard the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the speech of the heavens.

Ask him to open your ears to hear it.

Tell him where you have been deaf.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 746 · WEEK 107

Psalm 116

I will call on the name of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 116. Romans 10:13 says that everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved. This psalm is a testimony of someone who did exactly that. Notice the movement from near-death to thanksgiving.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 116 is a song of thanksgiving by someone who has been rescued from death. It is part of the Hallel (Psalms 113 to 118) that Jews sang at Passover. On the night before he was crucified, Jesus and his disciples would have sung these psalms after the supper (Matthew 26:30). So these words were in the air in the upper room. The phrase "call on the name of the LORD" appears four times and links to Romans 10.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice and my pleas for mercy" (v. 1).
2. "The snares of death encompassed me; the pangs of Sheol laid hold on me; I suffered distress and anguish" (v. 3).
3. "Then I called on the name of the LORD: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!" (v. 4).
4. "Gracious is the LORD, and righteous; our God is merciful" (v. 5).
5. "For you have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling" (v. 8).
6. "What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?" (v. 12).
7. "I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD" (v. 13).
8. "Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints" (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with love: “I love the LORD, because he has heard my voice.” Gratitude for answered prayer produces love. Because God inclined his ear, the psalmist says, “I will call on him as long as I live.” It is a lifelong promise.

Then he tells the story. The snares of death surrounded him, the pangs of Sheol laid hold of him. We do not know the illness or danger, but it was severe. “Then I called on the name of the LORD: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul!” It is a short prayer, the prayer of someone with no time for long speeches. And God answered. Notice what the psalmist says about God’s character: gracious, righteous, merciful, one who preserves the simple. “When I was brought low, he saved me.” The simple are not fools but those who depend on God rather than on their own cleverness.

The psalmist addresses his own soul: “Return, O my soul, to your rest, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you.” Rest follows rescue. He has been delivered from death, tears, and stumbling, and he resolves to walk before the LORD in the land of the living.

Then the question that fits all Christians: “What shall I render to the LORD for all his benefits to me?” How can we repay God? We can’t. The answer is surprising: “I will lift up the cup of salvation and call on the name of the LORD.” The way to respond to a gift is to receive it again, gladly. The cup of salvation recalls the cup of the Passover. For Christians, it recalls the cup that Jesus gave his disciples, the new covenant in his blood. We do not repay God; we take the cup and thank him.

Verse 15 says, “Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints.” For the believer, death is not meaningless. God notices and values the death of each one who belongs to him. The psalmist is also a servant, the son of God’s maidservant, whose chains the LORD has loosed. He promises to pay his vows in the presence of all the people, in the courts of the house of the LORD. Thanksgiving is public.

This is a good psalm to pray after a hard season. And when we read it as Jesus’ hymn, we see that on the night he was betrayed he sang of the cup of salvation, then went out to drink the cup of suffering. The LORD would deliver his soul from death, not by sparing him but by raising him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 10:13 and Joel 2:32 speak of calling on the name of the LORD. Psalm 113 to 118 are the Hallel. Matthew 26:27-30 and Luke 22:17-20 describe the cup and the hymn. 1 Corinthians 10:16 and 11:25 speak of the cup of blessing. Psalm 56:12-13 also gives thanks for deliverance.

Psalm 91 speaks of refuge and rescue. Philippians 1:21-23 speaks of death as gain. Hebrews 5:7 says Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries to him who was able to save him from death. Revelation 14:13 says blessed are the dead who die in the Lord.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the short prayer of verse 4 for a situation today: O LORD, I pray, deliver my soul.

Ask what you will render to the LORD for his benefits. Take the cup of salvation by thanking him aloud for specific gifts.

Next time you take the Lord's Supper, remember that Jesus sang this psalm.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you love him because he hears.
- Thank him for saving you from death.
- Ask him what you can render for all his benefits.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 747 · WEEK 107

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117, the shortest chapter in the Bible. Paul quotes it in Romans 15:11 at the climax of his argument that the gospel unites Jew and Gentile. You have read this psalm before. Read it today as part of Paul's closing argument in Romans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 sits at the center of the Bible in the Hebrew-English Bible's order of chapters, at the end of the Hallel's first half. In just two verses it calls all nations to praise the LORD. Paul will use it in Romans 15 as the proof text that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God for his mercy. Reading it in the middle of Romans, as we approach the practical chapters, we see the goal of the letter: a united people of Jew and Gentile worshiping one God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Praise the LORD, all nations!" (v. 1).
2. "Extol him, all peoples!" (v. 1).
3. "For great is his steadfast love" (v. 2).
4. "Toward us" (v. 2).
5. "The faithfulness of the LORD" (v. 2).
6. "Endures forever" (v. 2).
7. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 2).
8. "All peoples" (v. 1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm contains one command and one reason. The command: “Praise the LORD, all nations! Extol him, all peoples!” The reason: “For great is his steadfast love toward us, and the faithfulness of the LORD endures forever.” Notice again that the reason for the nations to praise is God’s love “toward us,” toward Israel. This is the logic of Romans 9 to 11. God’s faithfulness to Israel is the means by which the nations learn to praise.

In Romans 15:8-9, Paul explains: “Christ became a servant to the circumcised to show God’s truthfulness, in order to confirm the promises given to the patriarchs, and in order that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy.” Two parts of one plan: Christ confirms the promises to Israel (God’s truthfulness), and the Gentiles glorify God for his mercy. Then Paul gathers four Old Testament quotations, from the Psalms, Deuteronomy, the Psalms again, and Isaiah, to prove that the Gentiles’ praise was always intended. Psalm 117:1 is the third of these: “Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles, and let all the peoples extol him.”

Notice how Psalm 117 brings together the two terms that have occupied us in Romans. “Steadfast love” is the word hesed, covenant mercy. “Faithfulness” is truth, reliability. These are God’s grace and truth, the two gifts that came through Jesus Christ (John 1:17). On the cross, steadfast love and faithfulness met. The nations are invited to praise because they, too, can now rest on God’s mercy.

The psalm is brief because the message is simple: the God of Israel is the God of all, and all should praise him. Short as it is, it carries the entire hope of the Bible. The scattered peoples of Babel will be brought together before the throne. Revelation 7:9 pictures “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages” praising God. This psalm is a first sketch of that scene.

Make it your own. When you praise the LORD in church, remember that you are joining a chorus drawn from every tribe, and the psalm is calling more to join.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 15:8-12 quotes this psalm with Psalm 18:49, Deuteronomy 32:43, and Isaiah 11:10. Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all families of the earth. Psalm 67 and Psalm 96 also call the nations to praise. Isaiah 49:6 speaks of salvation to the end of the earth. John 1:17 says grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. Ephesians 2:11-22 says Jew and Gentile are one new man. Revelation 5:9 and 7:9-10 picture the nations in worship.

STEP 6

Application

Say the psalm aloud as a prayer. It takes about ten seconds.

Pray for the nations by name. Pick three countries and pray that they would praise the LORD.

Thank God that you are part of the people he has gathered from all the nations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise the LORD with all the nations.
- Thank him that Christ confirmed his promise to include them.
- Pray for the nations to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 748 · WEEK 107

Romans 12:1-13:14

Living sacrifice; love; governing authorities

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 12:1-13:14. Paul turns from doctrine to its practical results. Notice the word “therefore” that begins chapter 12, the call to a living sacrifice, the community ethics, and the instructions on government and love.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first eleven chapters of Romans explain what God has done. Chapter 12 begins, “I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God.” The mercies of God, everything described in chapters 1 to 11, are the basis for all Christian living. Doctrine leads to doxology (11:33-36) and then to duty. What follows is a practical guide for the believer’s life in the church, in the world, and under the government.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship” (12:1).
2. “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind” (12:2).
3. “So we, though many, are one body in Christ, and individually members one of another” (12:5).
4. “Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good” (12:9).
5. “Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good” (12:21).
6. “Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God, and those that exist have been instituted by God” (13:1).

7. “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law” (13:8).

8. “But put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires” (13:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“By the mercies of God.” The appeal is not based on threats or fear, but on mercy. Because God has saved us, we offer ourselves. “Present your bodies as a living sacrifice.” In the Old Testament, sacrifices were killed. Now we are living sacrifices, daily offering everything to God: hands, feet, time, money, vocation. This is “your spiritual worship” (or “reasonable service”). Worship is not only singing on Sunday; it is the whole of life offered to God.

“Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind.” The world presses us into its mold, and the Spirit transforms us from within. As the mind is renewed by the word of God, we are able to discern God’s will, “what is good and acceptable and perfect.”

Paul next calls for humility and sober judgment. We are one body with many members, and each has gifts: prophecy, serving, teaching, exhorting, giving, leading, mercy. Each is to be used with the right attitude: generosity, zeal, cheerfulness. Then follows a series of short commands on love in action, verses 9 to 21: genuine love, brotherly affection, outdoing one another in showing honor, not slothful in zeal, fervent in spirit, serving the Lord, rejoicing in hope, patient in tribulation, constant in prayer, contributing to saints’ needs, practicing hospitality. “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse them. Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep. Live in harmony with one another.” “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God.” And the climax: “If your enemy is hungry, feed him; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink… Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.”

Chapter 13 opens with a subject that has caused much discussion: governing authorities. “Let every person be subject to the governing authorities. For there is no authority except from God.” Government is a gift of God for restraining evil and promoting good. Christians should pay taxes and give respect where it is due. Paul was writing under Nero. Most interpreters note that this does not mean unlimited obedience: Peter and John said, “We must obey God rather than men” (Acts 5:29). When governments command what God forbids, believers must obey God. But the default is respect and cooperation.

Then Paul returns to love. “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law.” Love sums up the commandments. He closes with urgency: “The night is far gone; the day is at hand.” The return of Christ is nearer than when we first believed. So “cast off the works of darkness and put on the armor of light.” The last command is perhaps the best summary of sanctification: “Put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make no provision for the flesh, to gratify its desires.” This was the verse that Augustine read in the garden, and which led to his conversion.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 1 and Hebrews 13:15-16 speak of sacrifice. Ephesians 4:1-16 and 1 Corinthians 12 speak of the body and gifts. Proverbs 25:21-22 is quoted in verse 20. Deuteronomy 32:35 is cited in verse 19. 1 Peter 2:13-17 and Titus 3:1-2 speak of government. Mark 12:17 says to render to Caesar. Acts 5:29 and Daniel 3 and 6 show the limits of obedience. Revelation 13 is another view of the state. Matthew 22:37-40 and Galatians 5:14 say love fulfills the law. Ephesians 6:10-18 speaks of armor.

STEP 6

Application

Offer your body as a living sacrifice today. Choose one specific thing: your schedule, a talent, a habit.

Renew your mind by reading Scripture first, before the news.

Look for an enemy or difficult person to bless, and do something kind.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Present your body to God as a living sacrifice, and say what that means today.
- Ask him to renew your mind.
- Ask him to help you love without pretense.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 107

“Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

ROMANS 10:9

DAY 749 · WEEK 107

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Romans 10:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Because, if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved."

ROMANS 10:9

REST

Meditation

This verse is among the clearest statements in the New Testament of what it means to be saved.

"If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord." The earliest Christian creed is three words: Jesus is Lord. In the Greek Old Testament, "Lord" (kyrios) was the word for the name of God. To say "Jesus is Lord" is to say that Jesus shares the identity of the LORD. It is also a statement of allegiance: he is my master. In a world where Caesar was called lord, it was a dangerous confession.

"And believe in your heart." The faith that saves is not just agreement; it comes from the heart, the center of the person. It is trust, not just knowledge.

“That God raised him from the dead.” The resurrection is the center of the faith. It proves that Jesus is who he said he was, that his death was accepted, and that death has been defeated.

“You will be saved.” The promise is sure. Saved from the wrath, from sin’s power, and ultimately from death.

Notice that the verse joins heart and mouth. True faith naturally speaks. And verse 13 adds that it is open to all: everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.

When you doubt whether you are really saved, return to this verse and ask: do I confess that Jesus is Lord, and do I believe that God raised him from the dead? If so, you have the promise of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw the final stretch of Paul’s argument and the beginning of its application. In Romans 9, Paul grieved over Israel and taught that God’s word has not failed, because God’s purposes work by mercy and election, not by physical descent. Chapter 10 gave the message of faith: confess that Jesus is Lord, believe that God raised him from the dead, and call on his name, and faith comes from hearing the word of Christ. Chapter 11 asked whether God has rejected Israel and answered with the remnant, the olive tree, and the mystery of “all Israel,” ending in the doxology: from him and through him and to him are all things. Three psalms accompanied the reading: Psalm 19 on creation’s voice that goes out to all the earth, Psalm 116 on calling on the name of the LORD, and Psalm 117 on the nations praising. Romans 12 and 13 began the practical section, calling believers to offer themselves as a living sacrifice and to overcome evil with good.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul had great sorrow and unceasing anguish for those who did not believe. Who in your life do you carry that kind of burden for? What is one concrete thing you will do to pray for or reach out to them?

Romans 10:9 says to confess Jesus is Lord and believe that God raised him from the dead. What does it mean in daily life for Jesus to be your Lord, and not only your Savior?

Romans 12:1 says to present your whole self as a living sacrifice because of God's mercies. What part of your life is hardest to hand over? What mercy of God can you remember as you do so?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess Jesus as Lord, and thank him for raising him from the dead.

Thank him for the promise of salvation.

Rest in him.

DAY 750 · WEEK 108

Romans 14:1-15:13

The strong and the weak; welcome one another

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 14:1-15:13. Paul addresses a practical problem in the Roman church: believers who disagree about food and holy days. Notice how Paul handles disagreements on secondary matters, and how he grounds the call to welcome in the example of Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Roman church included Jews and Gentiles. Some Jewish believers continued to observe food laws and holy days; some Gentile believers did not. Each group tended to look down on the other. Paul does not tell them to ignore the issue. He gives guidance for how to live together when Christians disagree on matters that Scripture does not settle. This section is very relevant to the church today.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As for the one who is weak in faith, welcome him, but not to quarrel over opinions" (14:1).
2. "Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind" (14:5).
3. "For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's" (14:8).
4. "For the kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking but of righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit" (14:17).
5. "So then let us pursue what makes for peace and for mutual upbuilding" (14:19).

6. “We who are strong have an obligation to bear with the failings of the weak, and not to please ourselves” (15:1).

7. “For whatever was written in former days was written for our instruction, that through endurance and through the encouragement of the Scriptures we might have hope” (15:4).

8. “Therefore welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God” (15:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul identifies two groups. The “weak in faith” are those whose consciences are bound on matters like eating only vegetables or keeping special days. The “strong” are those who understand that all foods are clean and every day belongs to the Lord. The surprise is that Paul sides with the strong in belief (14:14, “I am persuaded in the Lord Jesus that nothing is unclean in itself”) but demands that the strong treat the weak with love.

The first rule: “Welcome him.” Do not despise or pass judgment. The one who eats must not despise the one who abstains, and the one who abstains must not pass judgment on the one who eats, for God has welcomed him. “Who are you to pass judgment on the servant of another? It is before his own master that he stands or falls.” Each should be fully convinced in his own mind, acting from faith: “Whatever does not proceed from faith is sin.”

The ground for this tolerance is Christ’s lordship: “None of us lives to himself, and none of us dies to himself. For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord’s. For to this end Christ died and lived again, that he might be Lord both of the dead and of the living.” We will all stand before God’s judgment seat, and each will give an account of himself. That should end our habit of judging others.

The second rule: do not cause others to stumble. “It is good not to eat meat or drink wine or do anything that causes your brother to stumble.” Freedom must be used with love. “The kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking but of righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.” We should pursue peace and upbuilding. “Do not, for the sake of food, destroy the work of God.”

Chapter 15 gives the pattern: Christ himself. “We who are strong have an obligation to bear with the failings of the weak, and not to please ourselves… For Christ did not please himself.” The example of Christ leads Paul to speak of the Scriptures: written for our instruction, that through endurance and encouragement we might have hope. And he prays for a church with one voice: “May the God of endurance and encouragement grant you to live in such harmony

with one another, in accord with Christ Jesus, that together you may with one voice glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ." The command is then repeated and grounded: "Welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God." Christ became a servant to the circumcised to confirm the promises, and so that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy.

This does not mean that everything is a matter of opinion. Paul is clear on the gospel, on sin, and on Christ's resurrection. The category of disputable matters includes issues the Bible does not settle. Wise Christians distinguish essentials, convictions, and preferences. On essentials, unity; on disputable matters, liberty; and in all things, love.

Paul closes with a blessing: "May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, so that by the power of the Holy Spirit you may abound in hope."

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 11 gives the food laws. Mark 7:14-23 shows Jesus declaring all foods clean. Acts 10 shows Peter's vision. Colossians 2:16-23 deals with food and festival. 1 Corinthians 8 and 10:23-33 deal with food offered to idols. Galatians 5:13-15 speaks of freedom and love. Philippians 2:1-11 calls for the mind of Christ. Psalm 69:9 is quoted in 15:3. Ephesians 4:1-6 speaks of the unity of the Spirit. Psalm 18:49, Deuteronomy 32:43, Psalm 117:1, and Isaiah 11:10 are quoted in 15:9-12. John 17:20-23 is Jesus' prayer for unity.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a fellow Christian you disagree with on a disputable matter. Welcome them in a concrete way this week.

Ask what freedoms you might lay aside for the sake of someone else's conscience.

Memorize Romans 15:7 and pray it for your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for welcoming you when you were far off.

Ask him to help you welcome someone he has welcomed.

Ask him to give you the mind of Christ toward those who differ.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons."

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 751 · WEEK 108

Romans 15:14-16:27

Paul's plans; greetings; the doxology

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 15:14-16:27. Paul explains his ministry and plans, then sends a long list of greetings. Notice the names, especially the women and the many co-workers, and the closing doxology.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul closes his letter by looking ahead. He has preached the gospel from Jerusalem to Illyricum, and now he plans to go to Spain, stopping in Rome on the way. First he must take the collection to Jerusalem. Chapter 16 reads like a list of names, but it is a window into the early church: women and men, slaves and free, Jews and Gentiles, house churches all over Rome. Every name stands for a real life changed by the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To be a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the priestly service of the gospel of God" (15:16).
2. "And thus I make it my ambition to preach the gospel, not where Christ has already been named" (15:20).
3. "I hope to see you in passing as I go to Spain" (15:24).
4. "I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant of the church at Cenchreae" (16:1).
5. "Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus" (16:3).
6. "I appeal to you, brothers, to watch out for those who cause divisions and create obstacles contrary to the doctrine that you have been taught" (16:17).
7. "The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet" (16:20).

8 “To the only wise God be glory forevermore through Jesus Christ! Amen” (16:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a compliment. He is satisfied that the Romans are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, and able to instruct one another. Yet he has written boldly, as a reminder. He describes his ministry in priestly terms: he is “a minister of Christ Jesus to the Gentiles in the priestly service of the gospel of God, so that the offering of the Gentiles may be acceptable, sanctified by the Holy Spirit.” The Gentiles, brought to faith, are his offering to God.

His ambition is to preach where Christ has not been named. Now that this work in the eastern Mediterranean is complete, he looks west to Spain. He asks the Romans to help him on his journey. Before he goes, he must take the collection from Macedonia and Achaia to the poor saints in Jerusalem, a sign of unity between Gentile and Jewish believers. “I appeal to you, brothers… to strive together with me in your prayers to God on my behalf, that I may be delivered from the unbelievers in Judea.” Paul would indeed be arrested in Jerusalem, as we read in Acts, and reach Rome as a prisoner.

Chapter 16 begins with Phoebe, a servant (or deacon) of the church at Cenchreae, who very likely carried the letter to Rome. Paul calls her a “patron of many.” Next are Prisca and Aquila, who risked their necks for Paul and host a church in their house. Epaenetus, Mary, Andronicus and Junia, Ampliatus, Urbanus, Stachys, Apelles, and many others follow. Paul names about thirty people, with warm words: “beloved,” “fellow worker,” “approved in Christ,” “workers in the Lord.” Women feature prominently. The letter reminds us that the gospel is carried by ordinary people with extraordinary faithfulness. Christians differ about roles of women in church leadership, but all should honor the labor of these women.

Right in the middle comes a warning: “I appeal to you, brothers, to watch out for those who cause divisions and create obstacles contrary to the doctrine that you have been taught; avoid them. For such persons do not serve our Lord Christ, but their own appetites.” Doctrine matters, and unity is not unity at any price. But the promise comes: “The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.” This echoes Genesis 3:15.

Tertius, who wrote down the letter, adds his own greeting: “I Tertius, who wrote this letter, greet you in the Lord.” It is a delightful reminder that this great letter was dictated and written by a human scribe.

Then the final doxology. “Now to him who is able to strengthen you according to my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery that was kept secret for long ages but has now been disclosed and through the prophetic writings has been

made known to all nations, according to the command of the eternal God, to bring about the obedience of faith, to the only wise God be glory forevermore through Jesus Christ! Amen." The letter ends where it began: with the gospel, the Scriptures, the obedience of faith, and all nations. The mystery of the ages is revealed in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 18:1-3, 18-26 tell of Prisca and Aquila. Acts 20:1-3 shows Paul at Corinth when he wrote. Acts 21 to 28 tell what happened after the collection. 2 Corinthians 8 to 9 describe the collection. Genesis 3:15 promises the crushing of the serpent. Colossians 1:25-27 and Ephesians 3:1-13 speak of the mystery now revealed. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says our labor is not in vain. Philippians 2:25-30 speaks of Epaphroditus. 3 John and Titus 3:9-11 also warn about division.

STEP 6

Application

Write down the names of five people who have served you in the faith. Thank at least one of them this week.

Ask what your ambition is. Is there a place where Christ has not been named that God is calling you to?

Pray the last doxology as your own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for those who have carried the gospel to you.
- Ask him to make you a faithful servant of his church.
- Praise him as the only wise God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 108

“But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons.”

GALATIANS 4:4-5

DAY 752 · WEEK 108

Review and Reflection

Unit 20 review, The New Covenant Explained, Romans

Year 2 · Unit 20 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
>
> ROMANS 8:1

REST

Meditation

Paul wrote this verse after the cry of Romans 7:24, "Wretched man that I am!" It is the hinge of the letter, where the argument of chapters 1 to 7 reaches its destination.

"There is therefore." This word connects to everything before it. Because of the justification in chapters 3 to 5 and the union with Christ in chapter 6, there is no condemnation. It is a conclusion, not a hope.

"Now." Not "someday" or "maybe." The verdict is already given. It is a present reality, not something to be earned.

"No condemnation." Not "less condemnation" or "reduced." None. Condemnation means the sentence of a judge. For those who believe, the sentence has been carried out on Christ.

"For those who are in Christ Jesus." This is the condition, and it is not a work. It is a place: in Christ. Those who are united to him by faith share his standing.

When your conscience accuses you, when Satan points to your sin, when you remember what you have done, say this verse. The charge against you has been answered. The sentence has been served. You are in Christ.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read Paul's letter to the Romans, the fullest explanation of the gospel in the Bible. It began with the theme, that the gospel is the power of God for salvation, and the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith. Paul showed that the whole world is guilty: Gentiles who suppress the truth, and Jews and moralists who judge others and do the same. In a doctrinal pause you thought about the wrath of God as his holy opposition to evil. Then came the great turn: the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, and sinners are justified by grace through faith in Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation. You studied justification by faith alone and Abraham as the model of faith. Three psalms of repentance, 32, 130, and 143, gave the heart's response. Romans 5 traced peace with God and the two heads, Adam and Christ. A doctrinal pause on union with Christ showed that believers died and rose with him. Chapters 6 and 7 dealt with slavery to sin, the holiness of the law, and the struggle within, and a pause on sanctification showed that God works in us both to will and to work. Romans 8 gave the summit: no condemnation, the Spirit of adoption, the groaning of creation, and the love of God from which nothing can separate us. Chapters 9 to 11 treated God's faithfulness to Israel, his sovereign mercy, the call to confess Jesus as Lord, and the doxology of the depth of the riches and wisdom of God. The Psalms 19, 116, and 117 sang the reach of the gospel to all nations. Chapters 12 to 16 turned doctrine into life: the living sacrifice, the renewed mind, love, government, welcome across differences, and a list of names that shows the gospel carried by ordinary people.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does Paul mean by "the righteousness of God" in Romans 1:17?

Read Romans 1:16-17 and 3:21-26. Is the righteousness of God a quality he has, a gift he gives, or both? How does it connect to Habakkuk 2:4, "The righteous shall live by faith"?

What is justification by faith alone, and why does it matter?

Look at Romans 3:23-28 and 4:1-8. What does "counted as righteousness" mean? How is faith related to works, and what changes in the Christian life if you get this wrong?

What is the role of the Holy Spirit in the Christian life according to Romans 8?

Reread Romans 8:1-17 and 26-27. What does the Spirit do for the believer: freedom, life, adoption, assurance, help in prayer? How is he connected to the hope of resurrection?

How does Romans 9-11 address the question of God's faithfulness to Israel?

Consider Romans 9:6, 11:1-5, 11:17-26, and 11:29. How has God's word not failed? What do the remnant, the olive tree, and the mystery teach about Jew and Gentile in God's plan?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the gospel Romans explains.

Thank him that you are justified by faith.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.